
Paper 2, Option 2H.2: The USA, 1955–92: conformity and challenge

Overview

This option comprises a study in depth of the USA in the years 1955–92, from post-1945 affluence, through racial and political protests in the 1960s, to the rise of right-wing groups in the 1980s and the development of bitter divisions between Democrats and Republicans.

Students will gain an in-depth understanding of the challenges posed to the American political system by popular protests and different styles of leadership, and the effects on society of widespread economic, social and cultural change.

Key topics	Content
1 Affluence and conformity, 1955–63	• Urbanisation and affluence: the changing nature of cities; expansion of the suburbs; highway development; growing ownership and use of cars; white collar jobs and service industries; consumerism and domestic technology. • Cultural conformity and challenge: suburban conformity and social change in film and TV; advertising; the challenge of teenage culture and music; 'beatnik' culture. • The civil rights movement, including the Montgomery and Birmingham protests; the impact of the Washington march; the Ku Klux Klan and White Citizens' Committees. • Kennedy's New Frontier: social welfare and unemployment programmes; environmentalism and expansion of the National Park system; the Peace Corps; the space programme; extent of Kennedy's domestic achievements.
2 Protest and reaction, 1963–72	• Civil rights: the significance of Malcolm X, Black Power and the Black Panthers; King's changing priorities, including the campaigns in Selma and Chicago; King's achievements and the impact of his assassination; the work of Cesar Chavez. • Protest and personal freedom: student protest; counter-culture and its key features; the growth of the women's movement; the impact of sexual liberalisation; the origins of gay rights. • Johnson's Great Society, 1964–68: tackling poverty and unemployment; improving housing and education; Medicare and Medicaid; civil rights laws; Johnson's achievements. • Reactions to the counter-culture, 1968–72: the rise of the 'silent majority'; the role of the media in influencing attitudes; the impact of events in Vietnam and at Kent State; Nixon's appeal and his attack on the Great Society.

Key topics	Content
3 Social and political change, 1973–80	• The crisis of political leadership: the impact of Watergate on politics and the presidency; Ford, Carter and a new style of leadership; growing political disillusion, including the impact of the Iranian hostage crisis; the political impact of environmentalism. • The impact of economic change on society: the effects of inflation on family incomes; the growth of homelessness; the oil crisis and the end of cheap energy; the impact of foreign competition; the response of the government. • Changing popular culture: business interests in sports; the fragmentation of popular music; contradictions in film and TV, including the depiction of political and social tensions and a return to escapism; developments in news media. • The extent of progress in individual and civil rights: the political and social impact of Roe v. Wade; women's rights; workers' rights; gay rights; Native American rights and the impact of Red Power; the status of black Americans.
4 Republican dominance and its opponents, 1981–92	• New directions in economic policy: the impact of Reagan's policies on workers and the family; the trade and budget deficit; the significance of Bush's decision to raise taxes. • The Religious Right and its critics: the promotion of traditional values; campaigns against abortion and homosexuality; Nancy Reagan's 'Just Say No' campaign; the growth of bitter political divisions and their significance. • Cultural challenge: trends in youth culture; the impact of technology on popular culture; the growth of cable television and the influence of MTV; the impact of the AIDS crisis; controversial social issues in film and television. • Social change: the changing status of ethnic minorities; the impact of black American success in politics, business, sport and popular culture; the extent of racial tolerance and integration by 1992; the impact of women in politics and the workplace; the changing status of women by 1992.

Knowledge, skills and understanding: